The Tale of Tom Kitten

BY

BEATRIX POTTER



Retold for you by the

JAMES ALBERT® LANGUAGE INSTITUTE

Meet the characters



Tom, Mittens & Moppet

three little kittens



Mrs. Tabitha Twitchit

their mother



Mr. Drake Puddle-Duck

a duck

Look at the pictures. What can you see?



Once upon *a* time there were three little kittens:
Mittens, **Tom Kitten** *and* **Moppet**.



Their mother, Mrs. Tabitha Twitchit, is having friends for tea.
She brings the kittens inside to wash and dress them.



First she scrubs their faces.



Then she brushes their fur
and combs their tails.



Tom is naughty. He scratches!



Mrs. Tabitha dresses them in clean clothes.
Tom is fat. Pop! His buttons burst off!



“Now go into the garden,” she says,
“and keep your clothes clean!”



Moppet and Mittens trip over their pinafores
and fall on their noses.



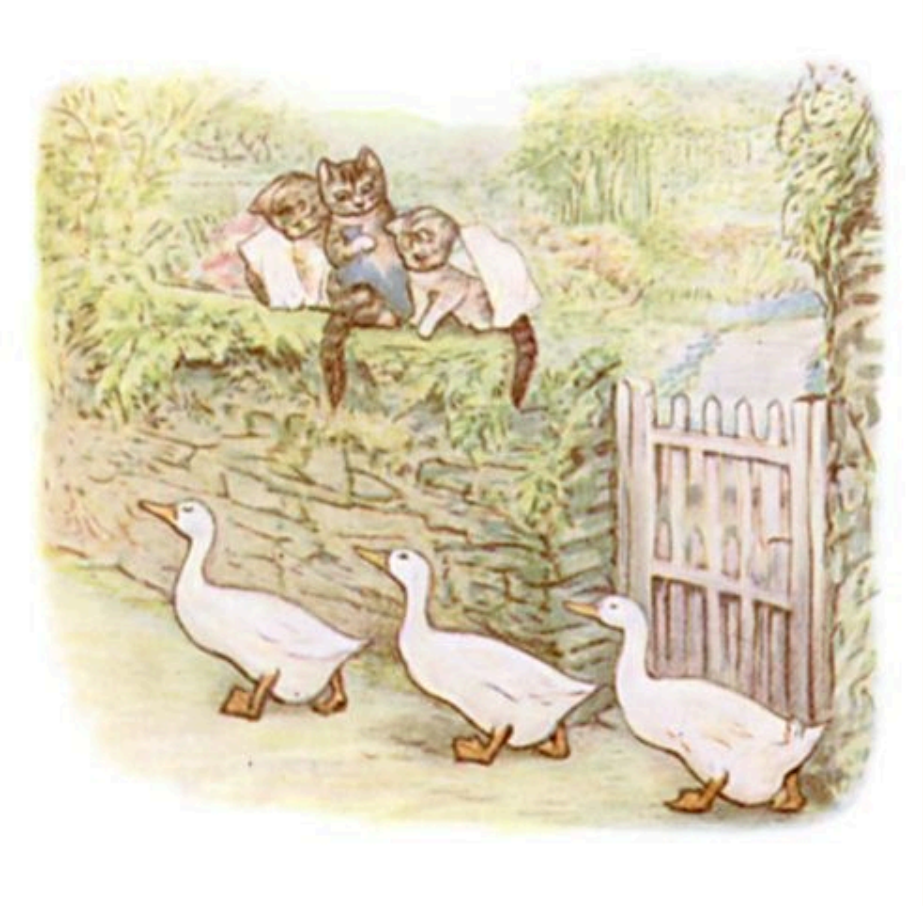
They climb onto the garden wall.



Tom can't jump in his trousers.
He climbs up through the plants and breaks them.



His clothes come off,
one by one!



Pit pat paddle pat!

Three Puddle-Ducks come along the road.



The kittens drop their clothes.
The ducks pick them up *and* put them on!



Mittens laughs so much
that she falls off the wall.



Mr. Drake Puddle-Duck is wearing Tom's clothes.
He looks very funny!



The ducks walk away up the road.
Pit pat, paddle pat!



Mrs. Tabitha comes into the garden.
Her kittens have no clothes on!



She is very cross.
She takes them back to the house.



“My kittens are in bed,” she tells her friends.



But the kittens are not in bed!
They are making a lot of noise upstairs.



And the ducks? They go into the pond.
All the clothes fall off in the water!



The Puddle-Ducks are still looking for them today!



The End

Words to learn

Parole da imparare

kitten	gattino
mother	mamma
face	faccia
fur	pelo
tail	coda
clothes	vestiti
buttons	bottoni
trousers	pantaloni
hat	cappello
garden	giardino
wall	muro
ducks	anatre
pond	stagno
clean	pulito
cross	arrabbiato

Let's talk!

Answer the questions · Rispondi alle domande

1. What are the kittens' names?
2. Who is coming to tea?
3. What happens to Tom's buttons?
4. Who takes the kittens' clothes?
5. Is Mrs. Tabitha happy or cross?
6. Where do the clothes go in the end?

Your turn

- Draw your favourite picture from the story and tell the class about it.
- Act out the story with your friends!

The original story

Beatrix Potter, 1907 · for parents and older readers

Author of "The Tale of Peter Rabbit", &c.

First published 1907

DEDICATED TO ALL PICKLES, —ESPECIALLY TO THOSE THAT GET UPON MY GARDEN WALL

Once upon a time there were three little kittens, and their names were Mittens, Tom Kitten, and Moppet.

They had dear little fur coats of their own; and they tumbled about the doorstep and played in the dust.

But one day their mother—Mrs. Tabitha Twitchit—expected friends to tea; so she fetched the kittens indoors, to wash and dress them, before the fine company arrived.

First she scrubbed their faces (this one is Moppet).

Then she brushed their fur, (this one is Mittens).

Then she combed their tails and whiskers (this is Tom Kitten).

Tom was very naughty, and he scratched.

Mrs. Tabitha dressed Moppet and Mittens in clean pinafores and tuckers; and then she took all sorts of elegant uncomfortable clothes out of a chest of drawers, in order to dress up her son Thomas.

Tom Kitten was very fat, and he had grown; several buttons burst off. His mother sewed them on again.

When the three kittens were ready, Mrs. Tabitha unwisely turned them out into the garden, to be out of the way while she made hot buttered toast.

"Now keep your frocks clean, children! You must walk on your hind legs. Keep away from the dirty ash-pit, and from Sally Henny Penny, and from the pig-stye and the Puddle-Ducks."

Moppet and Mittens walked down the garden path unsteadily. Presently they trod upon their pinafores and fell on their noses.

When they stood up there were several green smears!

"Let us climb up the rockery, and sit on the garden wall," said Moppet.

They turned their pinafores back to front, and went up with a skip and a jump; Moppet's white tucker fell down into the road.

Tom Kitten was quite unable to jump when walking upon his hind legs in trousers. He came up the rockery by degrees, breaking the ferns, and shedding buttons right and left.

He was all in pieces when he reached the top of the wall.

Moppet and Mittens tried to pull him together; his hat fell off, and the rest of his buttons burst.

While they were in difficulties, there was a pit pat paddle pat! and the three Puddle-Ducks came along the hard high road, marching one behind the other and doing the goose step—pit pat paddle pat! pit pat waddle pat!

They stopped and stood in a row, and stared up at the kittens. They had very small eyes and looked surprised.

Then the two duck-birds, Rebeccah and Jemima Puddle-Duck, picked up the hat and tucker and put them on.

Mittens laughed so that she fell off the wall. Moppet and Tom descended after her; the pinafores and all the rest of Tom's clothes came off on the way down.

"Come! Mr. Drake Puddle-Duck," said Moppet—"Come and help us to dress him! Come and button up Tom!"

Mr. Drake Puddle-Duck advanced in a slow sideways manner, and picked up the various articles.

But he put them on himself! They fitted him even worse than Tom Kitten.

"It's a very fine morning!" said Mr. Drake Puddle-Duck.

And he and Jemima and Rebeccah Puddle-Duck set off up the road, keeping step—pit pat, paddle pat! pit pat, waddle pat!

Then Tabitha Twitchit came down the garden and found her kittens on the wall with no clothes on.

She pulled them off the wall, smacked them, and took them back to the house.

"My friends will arrive in a minute, and you are not fit to be seen; I am affronted," said Mrs. Tabitha Twitchit.

She sent them upstairs; and I am sorry to say she told her friends that they were in bed with the measles; which was not true.

Quite the contrary; they were not in bed: not in the least.

Somehow there were very extraordinary noises over-head, which disturbed the dignity and repose of the tea party.

And I think that some day I shall have to make another, larger, book, to tell you more about Tom Kitten!

As for the Puddle-Ducks—they went into a pond.

The clothes all came off directly, because there were no buttons.

And Mr. Drake Puddle-Duck, and Jemima and Rebeccah, have been looking for them ever since.

About this book

The Tale of Tom Kitten is written and illustrated by Beatrix Potter (1866–1943). It was first published in 1907. The original text and illustrations are in the **public domain**: the author and illustrator died more than 70 years ago, so they are free for everyone to read and share (Italian Law no. 633/1941, art. 25; EU Directive 2006/116/EC).

Source of the original text and illustrations: Project Gutenberg eBook no. 14837 (public domain edition).

This edition — the retold text for young learners, the vocabulary and activity pages, design and layout — is original work by jamesalbert®.

© jamesalbert® 2026. All rights reserved for this edition.

Informazioni sul libro. *The Tale of Tom Kitten* è scritto e illustrato da Beatrix Potter (1866–1943), pubblicato per la prima volta nel 1907. Il testo originale e le illustrazioni sono di **pubblico dominio** (Legge 633/1941, art. 25; Direttiva UE 2006/116/CE). Il testo adattato, le attività, la grafica e l'impaginazione di questa edizione sono opere originali di jamesalbert® · © jamesalbert® 2026.

jamesalbert® Readers
Learn Naturally, Speak Naturally